



Homecoming: This marked Neeraj's first appearance on Indian soil since winning the Federation Cup in Bhubaneswar last year with a modest 82.27m effort. K. MURALIKUMAR

smallest delay had me fretting. But eventually, everything went well. The crowd was fantastic. The athletes were enjoying the atmosphere. And I won too. It felt so good," added Neeraj.

Bengaluru's reception shone through even before the shower of javelins started.

An hour before the first throw, Jan Zelezny, Neeraj's coach and the world-record holder, was swarmed by a horde of fans keen to get autographs and selfies. In a country where athletics coaches go undetected every day, it was a significant indicator of javelin's burgeoning stature.

For his part, Zelezny was an exuberant presence on the sidelines, constantly chipping in with suggestions to Neeraj, as he expectedly outshone the rest of the field. The home favourite's win, though, came in arduous circumstances as the Bengaluru weather decided to throw an unexpected spanner in the works, in the form of an agitated headwind.

Even when it appeared the throwers had achieved the perfect launch, the spear's trajectory was often hindered by the moody air current. Neeraj was the only one to cross 85m in the night as he claimed the inaugural NC Classic title.

Flanking Neeraj on the podium in Bengaluru were two throwers on different ends of the experience spectrum.

While the 36-year-old Yego was forced to dig deep to produce an 84.51m throw to finish second, the young Rumesh Pathirage continued his impressive progression.

The 22-year-old Lankan produced an 84.34m effort — the third-best throw of his career — to claim the bronze medal.

Among the other Indians in the field, Sachin Yadav, who recently claimed silver at the Asian Athletics Championships, finished fourth with 82.33m.

The experienced Rohler, though, failed to adjust to the challenging

conditions and was eliminated after the third round.

The churning headwind aside, the meet proved to be the perfect initiation for India to the bigger pastures of world athletics.

Speaking at the pre-event presser, Neeraj, sitting next to Germany's Rohler, suggested that the NC Classic will hopefully pave the way for more such elite competitions in the country, providing Indian athletes with a chance to rub shoulders with the best.

"We see so many competitions in Germany — A, B, C category. Similarly, I wish to see at least five to six such world-class competitions in India as well," said Neeraj.

Adille Sumariwalla, World Athletics vice president, backed Neeraj, saying it is imperative for India to host high-profile athletics events to boost its bid to bring home the 2036 Olympics. After the NC Classic, the former Athletics Federation of India (AFI) president announced India's

« Neeraj Chopra sealed the title with an 86.05m third-round throw, holding off Yego and Pathirage's strong challenges »